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TEA: BEHIND THE CUP

Social and environmental issues in the tea sector

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Transforming an industry shaped by two centuries of unequal trade

THE BOOK

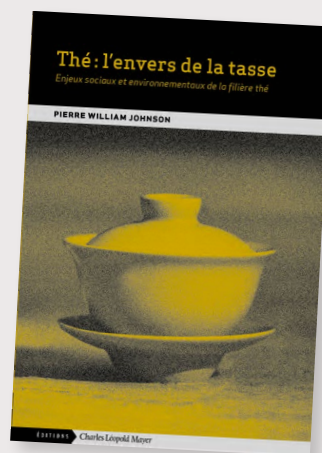
Tea is the most widely consumed beverage in the world after water, but what do we really know about the social and environmental backstage of the production and trade of these highly prized leaves? Less studied than cocoa or coffee, the tea industry remains neglected by advocacy campaigns and international policies.

Transformed during the 19th and 20th centuries by Europeans, particularly by the British, tea production still relies heavily on a social model inherited from their colonial past in the main exporting countries, located in South Asia and East Africa. Current commercial structures are dominated by a handful of corporations that mainly support a low-value-added monoculture model for a mass market that is not particularly concerned with quality.

Some governments are committed to changing the practices of tea plantations and processors, but the answers to the major challenges facing the industry will undoubtedly come more from ongoing developments in producer organization, the adoption of agroforestry models, the pursuit of quality, the sharing of best practices, and new relationships between producers, brands, and distributors with a better distribution of value. These are all avenues to explore in order to finally achieve a fair and sustainable tea.

THE AUTHOR

Pierre William Johnson is a trained socio-economist specializing in ecological economics, with expertise in the analysis and sustainable development of agricultural and artisanal value chains. He is the author of "Biopiracy: What Alternatives to the Plundering of Natural Resources and Ancestral knowledge, published in 2012 by ECLM.



Does this tea lover realise that most of the world's 13 million tea workers perform repetitive tasks and live below their country's poverty line?

That the neatly terraced rows of tea plants he so enjoys admiring are often nothing more than green wastelands contaminated by chemical pesticides?

INFORMATIONS

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